

Chapter 14

Artistic Innovations in Fifteenth-Century Northern Europe

Learning Objectives

1. Examine the characteristics of the luxurious International Gothic.
2. Discover the detailed naturalism and innovative techniques associated with Netherlandish painting in the fifteenth century.
3. Analyze the imagery and complex symbolism of Netherlandish paintings.
4. Trace the spread of Netherlandish styles into other regions of Northern Europe.
5. Explore the origins of print media.



Jan van Eyck DOUBLE PORTRAIT OF GIOVANNI ARNOLFINI AND HIS WIFE
1434. Oil on wood panel, 33" x 22-1/2" (83.8 x 57.2 cm).
The National Gallery, London. © 2016. Copyright The National Gallery, London/Scala, Florence

The Northern Renaissance

- Closely observing and detailing nature accurately through art became popular.
- The concept of individual personalities also rose to prominence, and more artists began to sign their work.
- The new power of Flanders and the greater Netherlands began to challenge the traditions of the Church.



FIFTEENTH-CENTURY NORTHERN EUROPE

The dukes of Burgundy—whose territory included much of present-day Belgium and Luxembourg, the Netherlands, and eastern France—became the cultural and political leaders of western Europe. Their major cities of Bruges (Belgium) and Dijon (France) were centers of art and industry as well as politics.

Art for the French Ducal Courts

- The dukes of Burgundy's rule encompassed Flemish and Netherlandish cities as well.
 - Dukes became the arbiters of taste.
- A composite style called the International Gothic prevailed in late fourteenth-century Europe.

Painting and Sculpture for the Chartreuse de Champmol (1 of 2)

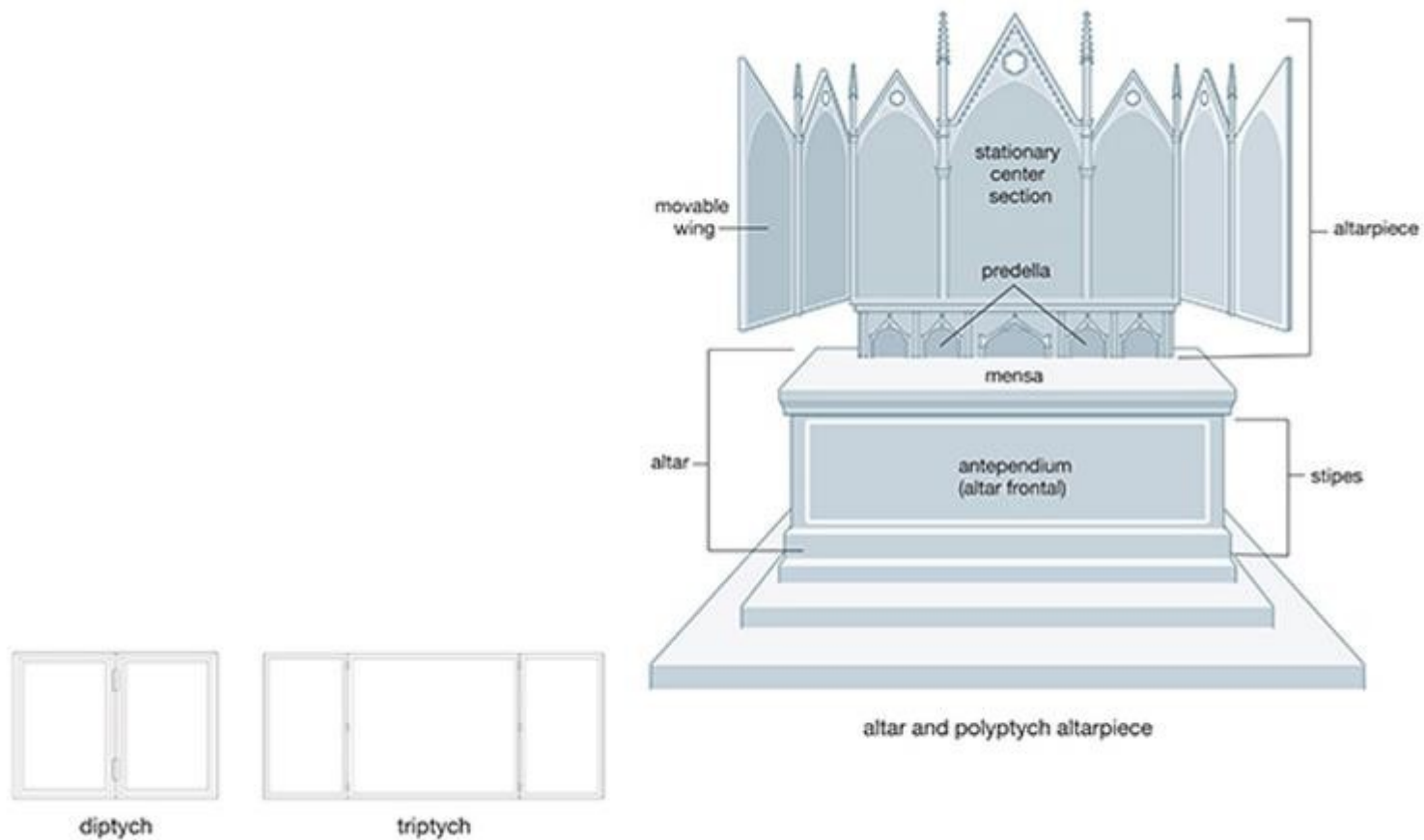
- Philip the Bold sponsored the building of the *chartreuse* at Champmol.
- Melchior Broederlam
 - The altarpiece called for scenes of the Adoration of the Magi, Crucifixion, and Entombment, which Broederlam renders in the International Style.



Melchior Broederlam ANNUNCIATION, VISITATION, PRESENTATION IN THE TEMPLE, AND FLIGHT INTO EGYPT
 Exterior of the wings of the altarpiece of the Chartreuse de Champmol. 1393–1399.
 Oil on wood panel, 5'5-3/4" × 4'1-1/4" (1.67 × 1.25 m).
 Musée des Beaux-Arts, Dijon. © akg-images/Erich Lessing.

Art and Its Contexts: Alters and Altarpieces

- As a table, the altar is a site where priests celebrate Mass.
- Altarpieces are painted, carved, and placed at the back of the altar so that they appear to join to the altar itself.
- A winged altarpiece could be a diptych, triptych, or polyptych, consisting of many panels.



ART AND ITS CONTEXTS: Altars and Altarpieces

Kathy Mrozek

Painting and Sculpture for the Chartreuse de Champmol (2 of 2)

- Claus Sluter
 - Sluter left the complex *Well of Moses* unfinished at the time of his death.
 - Figures of patriarchs and prophets serve as a pedestal for a free-standing figure of Christ on the cross.
 - He sculpted figures with voluminous drapery that created horizontal folds across their bodies.



Claus Sluter WELL OF MOSES, DETAIL OF MOSES AND DAVID
The Chartreuse de Champmol, Dijon, France. 1395–1406.
Limestone with traces of paint, height of figures about 5'8" (1.69 m).
© Paul M.R. Maeyaert.

Manuscript Illumination (1 of 4)

- Wealthy patrons treasured volumes of secular writing as well as religious texts.
- Only the most lavish books would have full-page miniature paintings set off with frames.
 - They were conceived as windows looking out at landscapes.



PAGE WITH A MINIATURE PAINTING OF THAMYRIS
 From Giovanni Boccaccio's *De Claris Mulieribus* (Concerning Famous Women). 1402.
 Ink and tempera on vellum, 14 × 9½" (35.5 × 24 cm). Bibliothèque Nationale, Paris.
 Bibliothèque Nationale de France, Paris.

Manuscript Illumination (2 of 4)

- The Limbourg Brothers
 - Three brothers became famous for their miniature paintings.
 - On the February page of *Très Riches Heures*, farmers relax before a fire.
 - Gothic conventions still seen in this work include the cutaway view of the house, attention to anecdotal detail, and the high placement of the horizon line.



Paul, Herman, and Jean Limbourg FEBRUARY: LIFE IN THE COUNTRY, TRÈS RICHES HEURES
1411–1416. Colors and ink on parchment, 11-3/8" × 8-1/4" (29 × 21 cm).
Musée Condé, Chantilly, France. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais/René-Gabriel Ojéda.

Manuscript Illumination (3 of 4)

- The Limbourg Brothers
 - The January page depicts an aristocratic household, barely hinting of the harsh winter represented in the previous work.
 - Luxury items attest to the wealth and lavish lifestyle of this patron of the arts.



Paul, Herman, and Jean Limbourg JANUARY: THE DUKE OF BERRY AT TABLE, TRÈS RICHES HEURES
1411–1416. Colors and ink on parchment, 11-3/8" x 8-1/4" (29 x 21 cm).
Musée Condé, Chantilly, France. Photo © RMN-Grand Palais/René-Gabriel Ojéda.

Manuscript Illumination (4 of 4)

- The Mary of Burgundy Painter
 - The painting of *Mary at Her Devotions* shows viewers two windows: one is the frame of the painting itself, and the other is a view into the far reaches of the church interior.
 - The message is of private faith.
 - Christians of this time were encouraged to imagine themselves within biblical events to feel a stronger connection.



Mary of Burgundy Painter MARY AT HER DEVOTIONS, HOURS OF MARY OF BURGUNDY
Before 1482. Colors and ink on parchment, size of image 7 1/2" x 5 1/4" (19.1 x 13.3 cm).
Österreichische Nationalbibliothek, Vienna. © 2016. DeAgostini Picture Library/Scala, Florence.

Textiles (1 of 3)

- Flemish textiles were treasured arts of the Renaissance.
 - They were portable, displayable symbols of wealth as well as practical means of warmth.

Textiles (2 of 3)

- The Unicorn Tapestry
 - The *Unicorn is Found* section of the *Hunt of the Unicorn* was preserved.
 - Subtle modeling indicates virtuosity of the weaver.
 - The natural world has symbolic meaning for the Resurrection in the lions and stag.
 - Plants and the unicorn itself carry other meaning as well.



UNICORN IS FOUND AT THE FOUNTAIN

From the Hunt of the Unicorn tapestry series. c. 1495–1505. Wool, silk, and silver- and gilt-wrapped thread (13-21 warp threads per inch), 12'1" × 12'5" (3.68 × 3.78 m). Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Gift of John D. Rockefeller Jr., The Cloisters Collection, 1937 (37.80.2). © 2016. Image copyright The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource/Scala, Florence.

Textiles (3 of 3)

- Cope of the Order of the Golden Fleece
 - This cloak served as a vestment for religious services.
 - Embroiderers worked with precision to match illusionistic effects being produced by contemporary Flemish painting.



COPE OF THE ORDER OF THE GOLDEN FLEECE

Flemish. Mid 15th century.

Cloth with gold and colored silk embroidery, 5'4-9/16" × 10'9-5/16" (1.64 × 3.3 m).
Imperial Treasury, Vienna. © KHM-Museumsverband.

Technique: Oil Painting

- Limitations of tempera paint resulted in the Flemish preference for oil paint.
- It is a viscous medium that has time to smooth out during the drying process.
- Additionally, it can be applied in thin layers called glazes that can create the appearance of an interior glow.

Painting in Flanders

- Civic groups, town councils, and wealthy merchants were important patrons in the Netherlands.
- Guilds oversaw nearly every aspect of members' lives.
 - Artists who moved from one city to another had to work as assistants until being granted guild membership, regardless of experience.

The Master of Flémalle (1 of 2)

- Robert Campin is identified as some art historians as being this master.
- The *Mèrode Altarpiece* is a triptych of relatively small size.
 - The Annunciation is the theme of the central panel.
 - Various symbols for Mary's virginity rest in a room that would have "hidden" them as a normal part of the setting.

The Master of Flémalle (2 of 2)

- The *Mèrode Altarpiece* is a triptych of relatively small size.
 - In the left wing, a married couple kneels in the garden of the house where the Annunciation is taking place.
 - In the right wing, Joseph is working in his carpentry shop in the foreground while a sumptuous scene of a Flemish street details the background.



Workshop of the Master of Flémalle **MÉRODE ALTARPIECE (TRIPTYCH OF THE ANNUNCIATION) (OPEN)**
 c. 1425–1430s. Oil on wood panel, center 25-1/4" × 24-7/8" (64.1 × 63.2 cm); each wing approx. 25-3/8" × 10-3/4" (64.5 × 27.6 cm).
 Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. The Cloisters Collection, 1956 (56.70). © 2016. Image copyright The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art
 Resource/Scala, Florence.



Workshop of the Master of Flémalle A FLEMISH CITY
Detail of the right wing of the Mérode Altarpiece (FIG. 19-10).
© 2016. Image copyright The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource/Scala, Florence.

Jan van Eyck (1 of 3)

- *Man in a Red Turban* strongly presents the sitter's personality, and it may have even been a self-portrait.
- A huge polyptych painted for the Cathedral of St. Bavo in Ghent is his best known work.



Jan van Eyck MAN IN A RED TURBAN
1433. Oil on wood panel, 13-1/8" x 10-1/4" (33.3 x 25.8 cm).
National Gallery, London. © 2016. Copyright Scala, Florence.

Jan van Eyck (2 of 3)

- The *Ghent Altarpiece*
 - The *Ghent Altarpiece* showed remarkable surface realism in textures such as jewels and human flesh.
 - Closed, its colors were muted and sober; when it opened on Sundays and feast days, it was vibrantly colored.
 - Some historians believe Hubert van Eyck began the painting, but others believed it was Jan's workshop.



Jan and Hubert (?) van Eyck GHENT ALTARPIECE (OPEN), ADORATION OF THE MYSTIC LAMB
 Completed 1432. Oil on panel, 11'5-3/4" x 15'1-1/2" (3.5 x 4.6 m).
 Cathedral of St. Bavo, Ghent. © akg-images/Erich Lessing.



Jan and Hubert (?) van Eyck GHENT ALTARPIECE (CLOSED), ANNUNCIATION WITH DONORS
Completed 1432. Oil on panel, height 11'5" (3.48 m).
Cathedral of St. Bavo, Ghent. © akg-images/Erich Lessing

Jan van Eyck (3 of 3)

- The Arnolfini Double Portrait
 - Early interpretations pegged the double portrait of *Giovanni Arnolfini and His Wife* as a wedding commission, but it has later been identified as a commission for a prospective marriage.
 - The artist signed his name within the mirror on the back wall.

Rogier van der Weyden (1 of 2)

- The peak of his career was spent in Brussels, where the artist was the official city painter.
- *Deposition* presented a popular theme for the time because of its dramatic, personally engaging portrayal.
 - Mourners have individual reactions to the scene.
 - Color and pattern enhance this piece.



Rogier van der Weyden DEPOSITION

From an altarpiece commissioned by the crossbowmen's guild, Louvain, Belgium.

Before 1443, possibly c. 1435–1438.

Oil on wood panel, 7'2-5/8" x 8'7-1/8" (2.2 x 2.62 m).

Museo del Prado, Madrid. © 2016. Image Copyright Museo Nacional del Prado. © Photo MNP/Scala, Florence.

Rogier van der Weyden (2 of 2)

- *St. Luke Drawing the Virgin and Child* is based on legend that Luke witnessed a miraculous appearance of the Virgin and Child so he could record their likenesses.
 - Art historians interpret it as a document of Rogier's sense of his profession; they also assert that it elevates the importance of painting as profession.



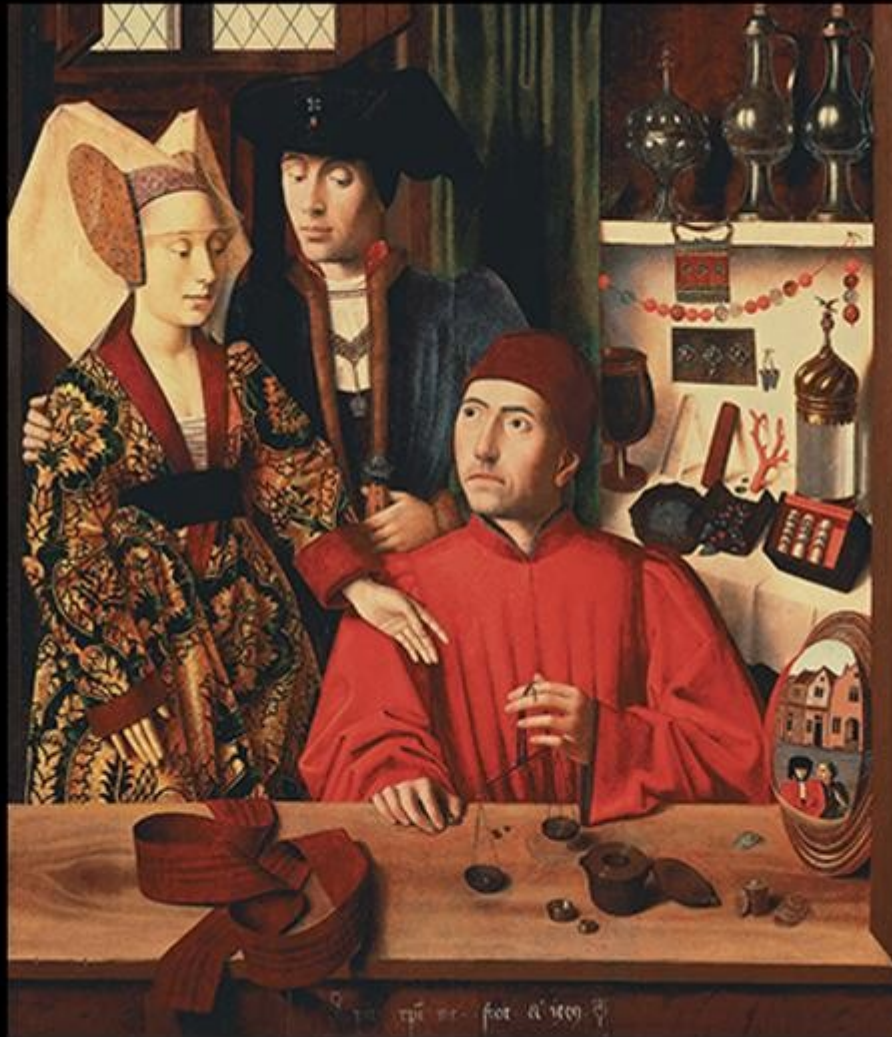
Rogier van der Weyden ST. LUKE DRAWING THE VIRGIN AND CHILD
c. 1435–1440. Oil and tempera on wood panel, 54-1/4" × 43-5/8" (137.7 × 110.8 cm). Museum of Fine Arts, Boston.
Photograph © 2017 Museum of Fine Arts, Boston.

Painting at Mid Century: The Second Generation (1 of 3)

- The second generation of Flemish painters produced work that was simpler, more direct, and easier to understand.
 - However, the work was more emotionally complex.

Painting at Mid Century: The Second Generation (2 of 3)

- Petrus Christus
 - The artist painted a portrait of a goldsmith serving two customers.
 - Originally thought to be an image of St. Eloi, it was reevaluated in 1993 as a portrait of an actual goldsmith.



A CLOSER LOOK: A Goldsmith in his Shop by Petrus Christus
1449. Oil on oak panel, 38-5/8 x 33-1/2" (98 x 85 cm).

Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Robert Lehman Collection, 1975. 1975.1.110. © 2016. Image copyright The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource/Scala, Florence.

Painting at Mid Century: The Second Generation (3 of 3)

- Dieric Bouts
 - *Virgin and Child*, at 8-1/2" tall, is an intimate rendering of a private moment between mother and child.
 - Both subjects look like people who would have existed during the artist's time.



Dieric Bouts VIRGIN AND CHILD
c. 1455–1460. Oil on wood panel, 8-1/2" x 6-1/2" (21.6 x 16.5 cm).
Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. © 2016. Image copyright The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource/Scala,
Florence.

Hugo van der Goes and Hans Memling

(1 of 3)

- The Portinari altarpiece was exceptionally large and its patrons were portrayed on the wing interiors.
 - Its theme was the Nativity as told by Luke.
 - Meadows and woods are meticulously painted and light plays a large role.
 - Symbols that viewers would have interpreted dot this work.



Hugo van der Goes PORTINARI ALTARPIECE (OPEN)
 c. 1474–1476. Tempera and oil on wood panel; center 8'3-1/2" × 10' (2.53 × 3.01 m), wings each 8'3-1/2" × 4'7-1/2"
 (2.53 × 1.41 m).
 Galleria degli Uffizi, Florence. © Studio Fotografico Quattrone, Florence.

Hugo van der Goes and Hans Memling

(2 of 3)

- Hans Memling
 - Memling combines intellectual depth and technical rendering with a delicacy of feeling and "prettiness."
 - He was commissioned to create a diptych of the Virgin and Child as appearing fictionally in the home of Maarten van Nieuwenhove.



Hans Memling DIPTYCH OF MAARTEN VAN NIEUWENHOVE
1487. Oil on wood panel, each panel (including frames) 20-1/2" x 16-1/4" (52 x 41.5 cm).
Hans Memling Museum, Musea Brugge, Sint-Jans Hospital, Bruges. © akg-images/Erich Lessing.

Hugo van der Goes and Hans Memling

(3 of 3)

- Hans Memling
 - Memling's construction of a coherent space is impressive in this format.
 - The Virgin's scarlet mantle extends under the division of the two wings to connect the pieces and rests under Maarten's Book of Hours.
 - A convex mirror reflects the backs of both Maarten and Mary.

France

- Under the rule of Charles VII and Louis XI, the French royal court became a major source for patronage of the arts.

Jean Fouquet and Jean Hey (1 of 3)

- Jean Fouquet
 - Fouquet drew from contemporary Italian Classicism and Flemish illusionism.
 - A diptych was commissioned for Étienne Chevalier to put over the tomb of his wife.



Jean Fouquet ÉTIENNE CHEVALIER AND ST. STEPHEN, VIRGIN AND CHILD
 The Melun Diptych, c. 1452–1455. Oil on oak panel. Left wing: 36-1/2" x 33-1/2" (92.7 x 85.5 cm), Staatliche Museen zu Berlin, Preussischer Kulturbesitz, Gemäldegalerie. ; right wing: 37-1/4 x 33-1/2" (94.5 x 85.5 cm), Koninklijk Museum voor Schone Kunsten, Antwerp, Belgium. © 2016. Photo Scala, Florence/bpk, Bildagentur für Kunst, Kultur und Geschichte, Berlin

Jean Fouquet and Jean Hey (2 of 3)

- Jean Fouquet
 - The left panel of the diptych features saint Stephen presenting the patron to the Virgin and Child in the adjacent panel.
 - The right panel of the diptych presents a supernatural, abstracted vision of the Virgin holding a substantial baby Christ.

Jean Fouquet and Jean Hey (3 of 3)

- Jean Hey, the Master of Moulins
 - The charming portrait of Margaret of Austria may have originally been a diptych.
 - Hey captures "Cs" and "Ms" embroidered on her collar that would have signaled her betrothal to Charles VIII, to whom she had been betrothed at age 2 or 3.
 - Her facial features are delicate and vulnerable.



Jean Hey (The Master of Moulins) PORTRAIT OF MARGARET OF AUSTRIA

c. 1490. Oil on wood panel, 12-7/8" x 9-1/8" (32.7 x 23 cm).

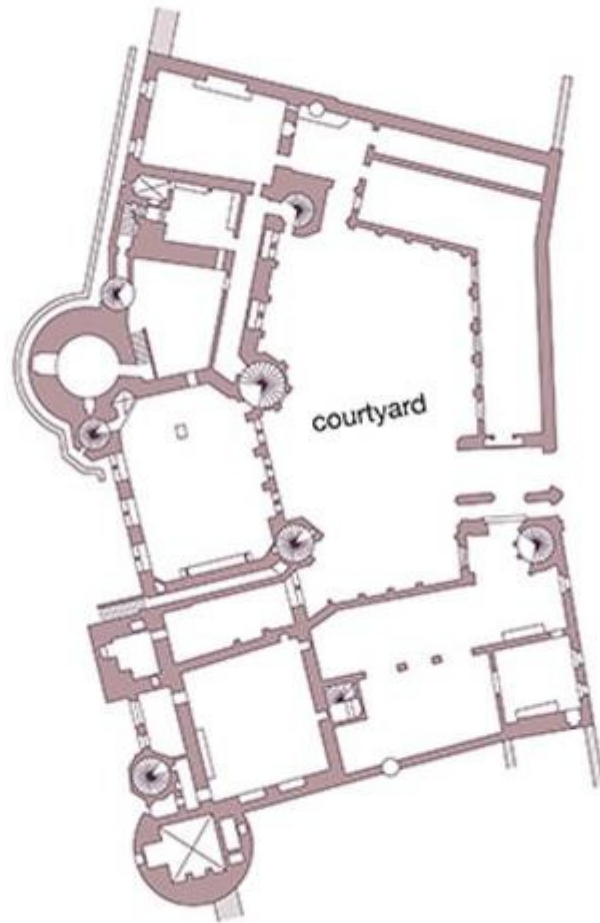
Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Robert Lehman Collection. © 2016. Image copyright Resource/Scala, Florence.

Flamboyant Architecture

- The Church of Saint-Maclou in Rouen is a well-preserved example.
 - Designed by Pierre Robin, it featured repeated, twisted, flamelike tracery.
- The house of Jacques Couer also retains flamboyant elements.
 - It is built around an irregular, open courtyard; tympana over doors indicate functions of the room within.



Pierre Robin (?) CHURCH OF SAINT-MACLOU, ROUEN
Normandy, France.
West façade, 1432–1521; façade c. 1500–1514
© Achim Bednorz, Cologne.



PLAN OF JACQUES COEUR HOUSE
Bourges, France. 1443–1451.



INTERIOR COURTYARD OF JACQUES COEUR HOUSE
Bourges, France. 1443–1451.
© Hervé Champollion/akg-images.

The Germanic Lands

- Artisan guilds grew powerful and trade flourished under the Hanseatic League.
- Konrad Witz
 - Witz found patronage through the Church.
 - *Miraculous Draft of the Fishes* sets the biblical scene on the Lake of Geneva, enhancing every surface texture with great detail.

Painting and Sculpture (1 of 2)

- Konrad Witz
 - Witz found patronage through the Church.
 - *Miraculous Draft of the Fishes* sets the biblical scene on the Lake of Geneva, enhancing every surface texture with great detail.



Konrad Witz MIRACULOUS DRAFT OF FISHES

From an altarpiece for the Cathedral of St. Peter, Geneva, Switzerland.

1444. Oil on wood panel, 4'3" x 5'1" (1.29 x 1.55 m).

Musée d'Art et d'Histoire, Geneva. © Musée d'art et d'histoire, Ville de Genève. Photo: Flora Bevilacqua.

Painting and Sculpture (2 of 2)

- Michael Pacher
 - Painter and sculptor Pacher was commissioned for a large altarpiece that survives in its original setting.
 - Open, it shows a sculptural ensemble flanked by four panel paintings.
 - Other artists collaborated with him for the execution of the work.
 - The use of soft wood allowed for high detailing.

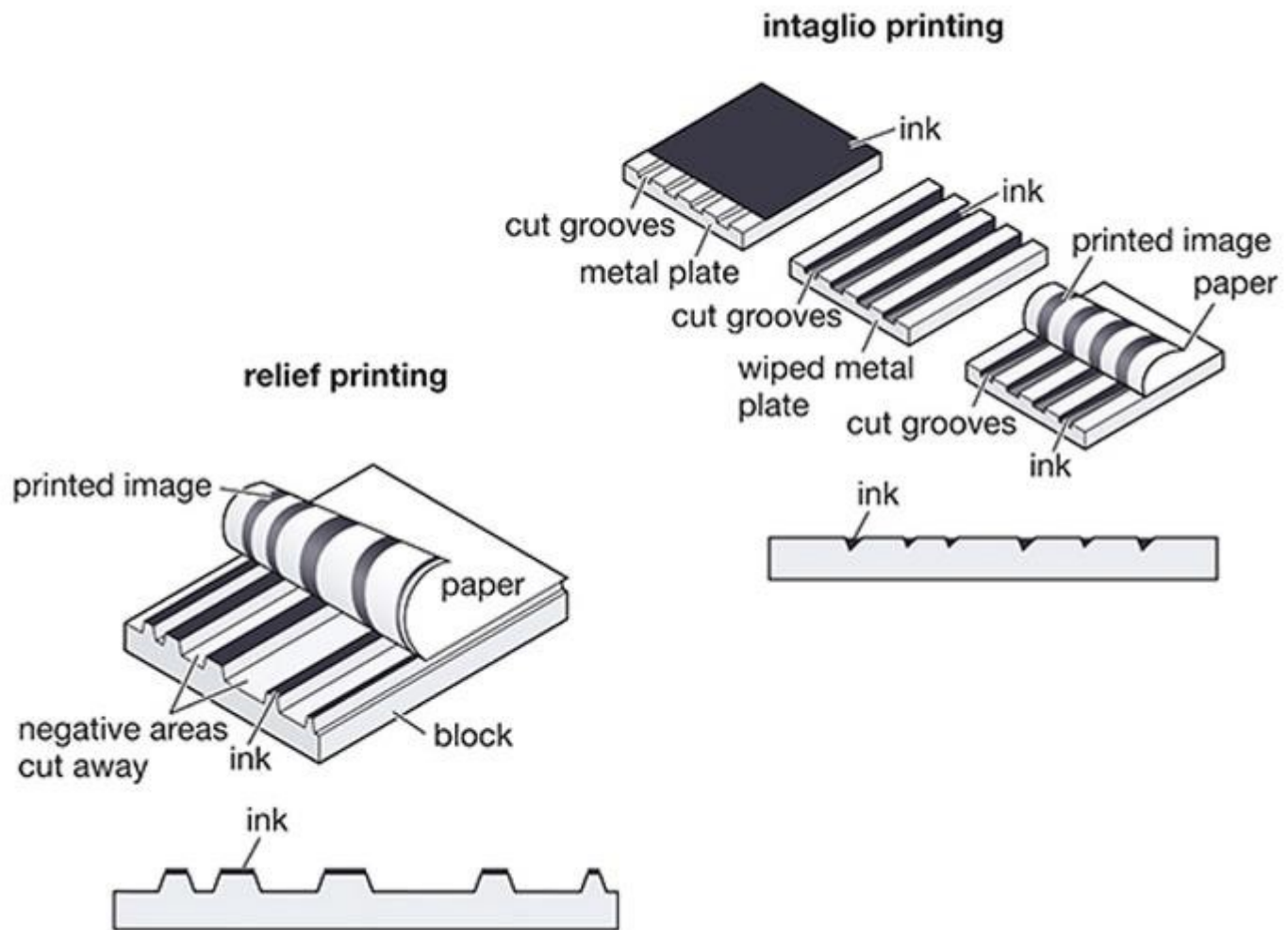


Michael Pacher ST. WOLFGANG ALTARPIECE
Church of St. Wolfgang, Austria. 1471–1481.

Carved, painted, and gilt wood; wings are oil on wood panel. © akg-images/Erich Lessing.

Technique: Woodcuts and Engravings on Metal

- **Woodcuts** are made by cutting away areas around drawn lines on a block, leaving the lines in high relief.
- **Engraving** uses **burins** to cut into the metal plate.
- Making multiple prints from a single version was a team effort.



TECHNIQUE: Woodcuts and Engravings of Metal

The Graphic Arts (1 of 3)

- Only in the fifteenth century did **woodblock** printing of images and text on paper replace copying of each book by hand.
- Woodcut and engraving were techniques used by printmakers.

The Graphic Arts (2 of 3)

- *The Buxheim St. Christopher*
 - This devotional image was glued to the inside cover of another manuscript.
 - Both the cutting of the block and the printing itself are high quality with varying line widths.



Christofon faciem die quacumq; tuas :-
qua nemp die mori mala non moriens :-
Millemo ecce
xx anno :-

THE BUXHEIM ST. CHRISTOPHER

Mid 15th century. Hand-colored woodcut, 11-3/8" × 8-1/8" (28.85 × 20.7 cm).
Private collection. © Fine Art Images/Archivi Alinari, Firenze.

The Graphic Arts (3 of 3)

- Martin Schongauer
 - Schongauer learned the technique from his father and produced *The Temptations of St. Anthony*.
 - The moment is presented as a horrifying assault, but the saint shows no sign of torment due to his inner focus.



Martin Schongauer THE TEMPTATIONS OF ST. ANTHONY
c. 1470–1480. Engraving, 12-1/4" x 9" (31.1 x 22.9 cm).
Metropolitan Museum of Art, New York. Rogers Fund, 1920 (20.5.2). © 2016. Image copyright The Metropolitan
Museum of Art/Art Resource/Scala, Florence.

Printed Books (1 of 2)

- The use of woodcuts for printmaking began to replace written manuscripts.
- Movable-type printing was achieved with the Gutenberg press.
 - This allowed for a number of identical books to be made concurrently.
- Rapid spread of these texts enhanced intellectual and spiritual life across Europe.

Printed Books (2 of 2)

- The *Nuremburg Chronicle*
 - The *Nuremburg Chronicle* was published in 1493 and contained 1,809 woodcut illustrations.
 - The panoramic *City of Nuremburg* spread was painted by hand with color to enhance its appeal.



Michael Wolgemut, Wilhelm Pleydenwurff, and workshop THE CITY OF NUREMBERG
Nuremberg Chronicle, published by Anton Koberger in 1493.

Woodcut within a printed book, hand-colored after printing,
 each page 18-1/2" x 12-3/4" (47 x 32.4 cm).